

Feminism

Origin , Development & Types

"You educate a man ; you educate a man . You educate a woman ; you educate a generation." - Brigham Young

"I hate men who are afraid of women's strength." - Anais Nin

• Introduction :

We are living in a male dominated society. Men are unanimously considered as stronger - physically and psychologically - across the whole universe. But it is a wrong belief and understanding. Men and women are equal and

must be given equal rights and privileges.

"Men are from Earth, women are from Earth. Deal with it." — George Carlin

Let's do an exercise :-

- Think of a **farmer** and give a name of any human being you know.
- Think of a **NURSE** and give a name of any human being you know.

Examine the history of any civilization, it is **"HIS" story**. This proves that women in all cultures, in all times have been subjugated, oppressed, exploited and dehumanized by men.

We consider women as a weaker class. Women continue to struggle at every moment and still seek their rights. This is precisely why a movement of Feminism started in all branches of knowledge. This movement of Feminism has opened up many debates around the world with a view to solve women's problems given them justice.

• Origin & Definitions of Feminism

"I myself have never been able to find out precisely what feminism is: I only know that people call me a feminist whenever I

express sentiments that
differentiate me from a
doomat - Rebecca West

"A feminist is anyone who
recognizes the equality and
full humanity of women and
men." - Gloria Steinem

Many researchers and scholars
have used the term feminism
and tried to formulate and
explain it differently. Some
refer to historical and political
movements in the United States
and Europe, while others
claim that women live unjustly
without rights and equality.

Zara Huda Faxis explained:
"Women need feminism
because there are women

who suffer injustice.”

The word feminism comes from French word féminisme and according to the Cambridge online dictionary feminism as :

“the belief that women should be allowed the same rights, power, and opportunities as men and be treated in the same way, or the set of activities intended to achieve this state.”

In short, feminism is an attempt to criticize male domination and demand women's rights.

The term feminism is used to describe a cultural, political or economic movement

aiming for equal rights for both women and men. The terms feminism and feminist gained widespread meaning in the 1970s when they started to be used in the public parlance more frequently.

• A Brief Historical Background of Feminism:

Britain as well as France were among the first countries where women started fighting for their rights, education and above all respect.

Simon de Beauvoir wrote that the first time we see a woman take up her pen in defense of her sex was when Christine de Pizan

wrote *Epître au Dieu d'Amour*
(Epistle to the God of Love)
in the 15th century.

However, it was not until
the early 19th century when
women began to achieve
changes in society, it was
Mary Wollstonecraft, author
of the commanding *Vindication
of the Rights of Woman*,
who received the lion's share
of attention. Wollstonecraft
was a woman who, as Arianne
Chernock says in her book
*Men and the Making of
Modern British Feminism*,
"Spoke up, quite loudly, for
what had been until then
a largely silent section of
the human race."

Scholars, even today, consider Mary Wollstonecraft to be a founding mother of British feminism and her 'Vindication of the Rights of Woman' can be considered as a first unambiguous feminist work.

• Waves of feminism :-

Feminists and scholars have divided the movement into three separate waves and each of the waves is significant for the movement in achieving different goals.

1. First wave :

The first wave refers mainly to the women's suffrage movement in the 19th and early 20th centuries in the United Kingdom, and

in the United States ,
focusing on women gaining
the right to vote. Originally ,
the first wave focused on
the promotion of equality
and property rights for
women and the opposition
to chattel marriage and
ownership of married women
and their children by
their husbands . Margaret
Waters writes in her
book called 'Feminism : A
Very Short Introduction',
"For a married woman ,
her home becomes a
prison-house . The house
itself , as well as
everything in it , belongs
to the husband and of
all fixtures the most

object is his breeding machine, the wife. Married women are in fact slaves, their situation no better than that of Negroes in the West Indies -

2. Second wave :

The second wave of feminism emerged after the World War II and can be described as the women's liberation movement, which focused on gaining legal and social equality for women, and most importantly on ending discrimination. This period was also understood as a continuation of the first wave of feminism,

in fact; the term 'first wave' was coined after the second wave emerged. Since the second wave had slightly different goal it needed a new term.

Second wave feminists discussed women's cultural and political inequalities and worked for to get the women a proper place and honor socially, culturally and politically.

One of the most influential feminists of the early 20th century was Simone de Beauvoir, who is also the author of 'The Second Sex' and of the very famous statement "one is not born, but rather

becomes, a woman."

• Third Wave:

The third wave of feminism or sometimes also called the post-feminism begins in the 1990's and continues up to present. Post-feminism refers to the perceived failures of the second wave feminism and it continues in fighting for the same beliefs as in for the previous waves. However, the movement's focus has slightly shifted; it is less focused on political processes and on laws but more on the individual self. Also, the feminists are more diverse now, the first and

the second wave feminists were mostly western, middle-class, white women, whereas the third wave feminists are women from different ethnicities, colors, religions and social backgrounds. Since 1990s women are more recognized in society and not only in the United Kingdom but also in other countries all over the world. It is because of this third wave of feminism that all across the globe mostly women have the same opportunities for education and can have the same occupations as men in all walks of life.

• Types of Feminism :

As with every social movement, feminism encompasses a variety of tendencies - There are three main types of feminism :-

- a) Socialist / Marxist / Materialist Feminism
- b) Liberal / Reformist Feminism
- c) Radical / Separatist Feminism
- d) Socialist / Marxist Feminism

a) Socialist Feminism :-

This type of feminism focuses on how women are done injustice in terms of class or gender inequality and inequality in private property. They raise questions as to why

women are not paid at home and outside home.

Mainly the Socialist feminists worked for the upliftment of economic and social status of women.

b) Liberal Feminism :

Liberal / Reformist feminists believe that gender inequality can be eliminated through legislative or electoral reforms without the need to alter the capitalist system itself. They advocated for the women's right to vote and their right to participate in governance.

c) Radical / Separatist Feminism:

Radical feminists target male psychology or biology, as the source of women's oppression. The most extreme form of radical feminism is separatism, which advocates a total break with men. They consider men as the super enemies of women and go to the extent of snatching away the rights and privileges of men in order to bring equality.

Major Feminist Writers,:

- Mary Wollstonecraft, A Vindication, for the Rights of Woman

- Maya Angelou, an African writer 'I know why the Caged Bird Sings' (1969)
- Margaret Atwood, a Canadian writer, 'The Handmaid's Tale' (1985)
- Jane Austen 'Sense and Sensibility' (1811), 'Pride and Prejudice' (1812), 'Mansfield Park' (1814), 'Emma' (1815)

Conclusion :- PUACP

All in all we may say that feminism as a separate movement started with the publication of 'Vindication of the Rights of women' by Mary Wollstonecraft in 1792.

As the whole feminist movement has developed over the centuries, and feminists have tried to raise the voice of the women socially, economically and politically.

During the 19th century writers have started addressing the topic of importance of independence for women, their need for acknowledgement and freedom. Whereas in the 20th century, when women finally gained their rights to vote, became respected in society and were more equal to men, writers wrote about new topics more openly which is also one of the main differences

in the development of
Literature -

